A Recipe for Entertainment

Take a video card with an onboard TV Tuner (such as the ATi ALL IN WONDER 9700 PRO or the COMPRO VideoMate from nVidia, or buy a PCI daughter card from the nearest hardware shop (*look to our Undercover report on page 82 for further information*). Add in coaxial cables to connect the card to your cable provider, throw in a hard disk big enough and spice up the mix with comfy seating, for one or two. There you have it, hot off the stove, a solution that will put your TV and VCR to shame. What you potentially possess is called a personal video recorder (PVR). The theory is simple: tune in to your favourite shows using the TV Tuner, and power up the software supplied alongside the hardware to encode and record the show on your hard disk. PVR also lets you pause a live show, head off for a snack or such, come back and continue watching the show where you left off. What's more, this 'time-shifting' also allows you to skip commercial breaks! All through the wonder of some encoding software and your handy hard drive.

Storage space is a potential bottleneck for PVR application. A movie encoded in MPEG-2 format, at a resolution of 720x480, running for a length of 1 minute with sound will take up half a gigabyte of disk space! This is where video codecs come in. Some of them are proprietary (such as the one supplied with ASUS cards) but all of them aim to alleviate the burden of disk space required to record your favourite shows.

resolution under *Quake III Arena*. As far as 3DMark scores are concerned, a number close to 2,000 should be considered adequate under this application area, while anything close to 5,000 should be looked upon as a good show. The GeForce2MX 200 card showed its age by posting just 1923 3DMarks under the 800x600 resolution—barely adequate. Even under the real-world DirectX test of *UT 2003*, this card did poorly, posting just 21.1 and 15.11 fps. Its OpenGL showing continued to be adequate—even in the newer engine of *Serious Sam*, the card posted above the 30 fps mark: 65.6 fps for 640x480 and 43.7 fps for 800x600. At Rs 1,750, only the MSI Trident T64 is cheaper, but this card beats the performance of the T64 by far. Consider it a buy if you are in the market for an inexpensive deal.

This card's elder sibling, the GeForce2MX 400 TV-OUT, did worse, although it possessed a theoretically greater bandwidth. A TV Out port granted this one a greater cost of Rs 2,750. Competing head-to-head, we found the MSI version of the same chipset in their MSI MX400 Pro64S GeForce2MX 400 card. Although quite a mouthful, the card bettered its rival by far, scoring 226.5 fps as opposed to 95.5 fps in *Quake III Arena* at 640x480 and 4343 3DMarks against the ENNYAH's 1878 score. It also did surprisingly well in the *UT 2003* tests, posting 43.52 fps at 640x480 and 31.28 fps at 800x600 resolution. Its performance comes at a price, however—at Rs 4,300, the card is twice as expensive as the ENNYAH, although its performance certainly reflects that difference.

To buy a GeForce2MX chipset at prices around the Rs 4,000 mark is not very advisable; you should rather opt for the newer and more feature-rich GeForce4MX-based solutions. ENNYAH offers three variants of this chipset: the Digiforum GeForce4MX 420 TV-OUT is based on the 420 chipset, while the Digiforum GeForce4MX 440 TV-OUT-4X/8X are based on the 440 chipset which along with support for AGP 4X/8X, provide greater bandwidth for transfering data between the CPU and video card. The flavours perform to satisfaction, posting scores greater than 200 fps under *Quake III Arena*